

KS₃: HISTORY OF AUSTRALIA

COURSE TEXTBOOK & TEXTBOOK

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L1: Claiming Australia

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the dual purpose of James Cook's voyage, contrasting the public scientific mission with the secret government orders to claim territory.
- ☐ Analyse the indispensable navigational and diplomatic contributions of the Polynesian high priest and master star navigator, Tupaia.
- ☐ Evaluate the first encounter at Botany Bay in 1770 from both the British perspective and the defensive spiritual perspective of the Gweagal people.

Do Now Activity

1. What cash crop drove the transatlantic slave trade and brought immense wealth to British traders and plantation owners in the seventeenth century?
2. Which Tudor queen granted royal charters to English adventurers like Sir Walter Raleigh to explore and claim lands in the Americas in the 1580s?
3. What dramatic population shift occurred in Great Britain between 1750 and 1850 as a direct result of the Industrial Revolution?

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Ancestors | Botany Bay | Colony | Gweagal | Navigator | Royal Society

In August 1768, Captain James Cook set sail on the Endeavour, funded by the _____ to observe the stars. In April 1770, the ship arrived on the east coast of Australia at a place they named _____. Here, they had a tense first meeting with the _____ people, whose _____ had lived on that coastline for thousands of years. Cook eventually sailed north and claimed the land as a British _____ called New South Wales, guided along the way by a master Polynesian _____ named Tupaia.

A Portrait of Captain James Cook

Source A: A portrait of Captain James Cook, painted by Nathaniel Dance-Holland in 1776.

Secret Instructions to Captain Cook

"You are also with the Consent of the Natives to take possession of Convenient Situations in the Country in the Name of the King of Great Britain; or, if you find the Country uninhabited take Possession for His Majesty by setting up Proper Marks and Inscriptions, as first discoverers and possessors."

Source B: Extract from the Secret Instructions issued to Captain James Cook by the British Admiralty, 1768.

In August 1768, Lieutenant James Cook, an officer in the British Navy, left Plymouth on his ship, the Endeavour. This voyage was destined to change global history. Publicly, the journey was funded and framed as a peaceful mission of scientific discovery. On board were nine scientists from the prestigious [Royal Society], led by the wealthy and influential young botanist Sir Joseph Banks. Their official, public

task was to travel to the South Pacific island of Tahiti to observe the transit of the planet Venus across the Sun. By timing this event from different parts of the world, scientists hoped to calculate the exact distance between the Earth and the Sun.

However, scientific curiosity was only a cover story. Cook also carried a packet of secret instructions from the British Admiralty. These private orders commanded him that once the scientific observations in Tahiti were complete, he was to sail further south into the uncharted waters of the Pacific to search for a rumored, massive landmass known as the 'Great Southern Land.' If he located this land, he was ordered to map its coastline, record its resources, and claim it for the British Crown before other rival European nations, like France or Spain, could do so.

While British history books have celebrated Captain Cook's navigational genius for centuries, the survival and success of the Endeavour relied heavily on an extraordinary Indigenous figure: Tupaia. Joining the ship in Tahiti in 1769 at the urging of Joseph Banks, Tupaia was a high priest and master star navigator from the island of Ra'iatea. While Cook possessed state-of-the-art European maritime instruments like sextants, compasses, and marine clocks, he had no charts or understanding of the vast, complex, and dangerous Pacific reefs.

Tupaia possessed an exceptional, complex mental map spanning over 3,000 miles of ocean. He navigated using ancient, highly sophisticated Polynesian star navigation techniques. Without any mechanical tools, Tupaia could determine the ship's exact position by reading the stars, the path of the sun, bird flight patterns, cloud formations, and the unique temperature and vibration of ocean currents. Furthermore, Tupaia was a brilliant diplomat. As the only person on board who could speak languages closely related to the Pacific islanders, he served as a translator when the Endeavour reached New Zealand. He communicated directly with the Māori, defusing highly dangerous misunderstandings and preventing what would have been catastrophic colonial massacres. Despite saving the lives of the crew and creating a detailed chart of the islands, Tupaia's pivotal role was written out of mainstream history for over 250 years, leaving his story largely 'invisible.'

In April 1770, the Endeavour sailed up the eastern coast of Australia. Although Dutch explorers had mapped parts of the western coast in the seventeenth century, they had never claimed ownership of the land. When Cook's crew located a sheltered bay and rowed toward the shore, they were met by two Gweagal Aboriginal men of the Dharawal nation armed with spears and shields. The Gweagal's ancestors had lived in harmony with that land for over 65,000 years.

From the spiritual and legal perspective of the Gweagal, it was their sacred duty to protect their ancestral country from uninvited strangers who did not have permission to be there. Cook wrote in his journal that when one of the Gweagal men threw a rock to warn them away, the British fired a warning musket. When the warriors stood their ground and a spear was thrown, the British fired two more times with buckshot, wounding one of the Gweagal men in the leg. Cook framed this in his records as an unprovoked attack by 'natives' on peaceful explorers, completely ignoring that the British were armed invaders. The Endeavour stayed in the bay for a week. Sir Joseph Banks and his scientists were so amazed by the thousands of unknown botanical specimens they collected that they named the place 'Botany Bay.' In May, Cook sailed north to an island he named 'Possession Island,' where he raised the Union Jack and claimed the entire eastern coast for Britain, naming it 'New South Wales' under the legal fiction of 'Terra Nullius' (nobody's land).

Active Tasks

Q1.

L2: Creating a Convict Colony

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain how the loss of the American colonies in 1776 directly caused a prison crisis in Britain that led to the system of transportation.
- ☐ Describe the physical and environmental challenges faced by Captain Arthur Phillip and the convicts during their first year at Sydney Cove.
- ☐ Analyse the work and social conditions of the convicts, contrasting general labor with the punishments of the chain road gangs.

Do Now Activity

1. What was the secret reason the British Admiralty gave Captain Cook private instructions to explore the South Pacific?
2. Who was the master Polynesian star navigator and high priest who used his mental map of the ocean to guide the Endeavour?
3. What did the Gweagal Aboriginal warriors throw at Captain Cook's men during their first meeting at Botany Bay in 1770?

Vocabulary Check

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

Convict | Governor | Hard labour | Hulk | Transportation | Sydney Harbour

Your Sentence:

Prison Hulks on the Thames

Source C: An 1806 sketch by Edward William Cooke depicting prison hulks moored in the Thames.

During the eighteenth century, the British legal system relied heavily on the Transportation Act of 1717 to deal with criminals. Under this system, the courts sentenced thousands of petty thieves to be sent to Britain's colonies in North America, where their labor was sold to tobacco plantation owners. However, in 1776, the American colonies declared their independence from Great Britain. This political revolution meant that sending British criminals to America was no longer possible, creating a severe and immediate prison crisis back in Britain.

British gaols quickly became dangerously overcrowded. To cope with this, the government passed the Hulks Act of 1776, which allowed them to lock prisoners inside 'hulks'—old, decommissioned warships moored in southern English ports like Portsmouth and Plymouth. These floating prisons were horrific: they were dark, suffocatingly hot, filthy, and disease-ridden, with thousands of prisoners dying of typhus and cholera. As public panic rose over the disease and frequent prison escapes, the British government realized they needed a permanent, distant alternative. In August 1786, they decided to establish a new penal colony on the eastern coast of Australia, which Captain Cook had claimed eighteen years earlier.

In May 1787, the First Fleet—a group of eleven ships carrying approximately 1,400 people, including 750 convicts, marines, and sailors—departed Portsmouth under the command of Captain Arthur Phillip, who was appointed as the colony's first [Governor]. After an arduous, eight-month voyage, the fleet reached Botany Bay in January 1788. Phillip quickly realized the bay was too shallow and open to heavy winds, so he sailed slightly north to Port Jackson, establishing the settlement of Sydney Cove on January 26, 1788.

The arrival was marked by extreme physical and social chaos. On Wednesday, February 6, 1788, the

female convicts were finally brought ashore from their transport ships. Arthur Bowes Smyth, a naval surgeon aboard the Lady Penrhyn (the ship carrying the majority of the female convicts), kept a highly detailed, eyewitness journal of that day. He recorded that as the women landed, a violent, terrifying tropical thunderstorm struck Sydney Cove, splitting a massive tree in the center of the camp and killing several sheep. Smyth described scenes of absolute riot and heavy drinking as sailors and male convicts broke into the women's tents. Bowes Smyth's journals are invaluable to historians today because they provide a rare, human face to the female convicts, recording their actual names, ages, trades, and personal struggles during the settlement's birth.

The first year of the Sydney settlement was an intense struggle for survival. The colonists faced immediate starvation because the sandy soil around Sydney Cove was poor, the local climate was completely unfamiliar, and there were almost no skilled farmers, blacksmiths, or carpenters among the convicts. To prevent a total collapse and preserve order, Governor Phillip took the radical step of ordering that all food supplies be rationed completely equally between the officers, soldiers, and convicts.

To build the colony from scratch, every convict was forced into grueling [Hard labour]. During the day, they felled massive trees, cleared dense bush, grew food, and quarried sandstone blocks to construct the first barracks. Convicts who refused to work, stole food, or committed other offenses were severely punished. Many were sent to join a 'road gang'—forced to work day after day with their legs locked in heavy iron chains, breaking stones and shoveling earth to build Australia's first roads. Despite this brutal regime, by the 1820s, this forced manual labor had successfully transformed the wild bushland of Sydney into a thriving, highly profitable colonial port.

Active Tasks

Q1.

Q2.

L3: Encounters with the Indigenous Peoples

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the impact of European diseases on the Aboriginal population.
- ☐ Analyze the resistance of Aboriginal leaders like Pemulwuy.
- ☐ Examine the Myall Creek Massacre as an example of frontier violence.

Do Now Activity

1. What was the name of the Polynesian navigator who sailed with Captain Cook on the Endeavour?
2. What was the primary reason the British government established a penal colony at Botany Bay in 1788?

Vocabulary Check

Write a clear definition and a historically accurate sentence for the term: **Frontier**

Before the First Fleet departed, King George III explicitly instructed Governor Arthur Phillip to 'endeavour by every possible means to open an intercourse with the natives, and to conciliate their affections.' The official policy was one of 'amity and kindness.' However, this completely ignored the reality that the British were arriving to permanently occupy land that had been inhabited by Aboriginal Australians for over 60,000 years. The concept of 'terra nullius' (nobody's land) meant the British legally pretended the Indigenous owners did not exist, setting the stage for inevitable conflict.

The most immediate and catastrophic impact of the British arrival was not guns, but disease. In 1789, a horrifying outbreak of smallpox swept through the Aboriginal communities around Sydney Cove. Having been isolated from the rest of the world for millennia, the Indigenous population had zero natural immunity. The results were apocalyptic. It is estimated that up to 70% of the local Cadigal and surrounding populations died within months. Families were destroyed, and ancient knowledge, traditions, and social structures were severely disrupted, leaving the survivors deeply vulnerable to the expanding colony.

Despite the devastating impact of disease, Aboriginal resistance was fierce and highly organized. The most famous resistance leader was Pemulwuy, a Bidjigal man. From 1790 to 1802, Pemulwuy led a brilliant campaign of guerrilla warfare against the British settlers who were stealing their hunting grounds along the Hawkesbury River. He burned crops, raided farms, and speared livestock, repeatedly outsmarting the British military. He survived multiple bullet wounds, leading his people to believe he was invincible. Tragically, in 1802, he was finally shot and killed. In a grim reflection of colonial attitudes, his head was severed and sent to London to join the dark collection of human skulls maintained by Sir Joseph Banks, the botanist from Cook's Endeavour voyage.

As the frontier pushed further inland, the violence became increasingly brutal. One of the most infamous atrocities occurred in 1838 at Myall Creek in New South Wales. A group of eleven heavily armed stockmen (mostly ex-convicts) rode into a camp of peaceful Weraera people. Without provocation, they rounded up 28 unarmed elders, women, and children, tied them together, and systematically slaughtered them with swords and pistols, later burning the bodies. What made Myall Creek historically significant was not just the horrific violence, but that the perpetrators were actually arrested, tried, and seven were hanged. This was the first time in Australian history that white men were executed for the murder of Aboriginal people. However, it did not stop the frontier violence; it merely forced it underground, leading settlers to use poisoned flour rather than guns to avoid arrest.

Active Tasks

Q1.

L4: From Penal Colony to Settlement

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the role of the wool industry in making the colony economically viable.
- ☐ Analyze the impact of the 1850s gold rushes on Australian society.
- ☐ Examine the experiences and treatment of Chinese gold miners.

Do Now Activity

1. Who was the Bidjigal leader that waged a 12-year guerrilla war against the British settlers?

2. Why is the Myall Creek Massacre historically significant?

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Squatter | Merino | Immigrant | Xenophobia

The early Australian economy relied heavily on the _____ sheep industry, driven by wealthy _____ farmers. Later, the gold rushes attracted thousands of every type of _____, though the sudden arrival of Chinese miners sparked intense _____ and racist legislation.

For its first few decades, New South Wales was an expensive burden on the British taxpayer. It was essentially a massive outdoor prison that struggled to feed itself. This changed with the introduction of the Merino sheep by wealthy landowners like John Macarthur. The dry Australian climate was perfectly suited to sheep farming, and the seemingly endless tracts of land allowed for massive flocks. Enterprising men known as 'squatters' pushed far beyond the official boundaries of settlement, claiming vast areas of Aboriginal land to graze their sheep. By the 1830s, Australia was exporting millions of pounds of high-quality wool to feed the ravenous textile mills of the British Industrial Revolution. The colony was finally profitable.

If wool made Australia profitable, gold made it incredibly wealthy. In 1851, payable gold was discovered near Bathurst, New South Wales, and shortly after, massive fields were found in Victoria. The news sparked a global frenzy. Almost overnight, the image of Australia shifted from a dreaded, miserable convict prison to a land of unlimited opportunity. Between 1851 and 1860, the population of Australia nearly tripled, surging from 430,000 to over 1.1 million. Free immigrants flooded in from Britain, America, Europe, and Asia. This massive influx of free, ambitious people effectively ended the transportation of convicts to the eastern colonies, as the British government realized they could no longer punish criminals by sending them to a land where people were becoming millionaires.

Among the hundreds of thousands of immigrants were over 40,000 miners from China. Fleeing poverty and conflict in their homeland, they came seeking 'New Gold Mountain.' Chinese miners were highly organised, hard-working, and often succeeded in finding gold in claims that European miners had abandoned. However, their success, combined with their different language, dress, and customs (such as wearing their hair in a traditional queue), made them targets of intense xenophobia and racism. European miners frequently harassed and attacked them, culminating in violent events like the 1857 Buckland River riot and the 1861 Lambing Flat riots, where Chinese camps were burned and miners were brutally beaten.

Rather than protecting the Chinese miners, the colonial governments responded to the riots by passing discriminatory laws aimed at keeping them out. Victoria implemented an unfair '£10 poll tax' on every Chinese person entering the colony (a massive sum at the time), and restricted the number of Chinese passengers a ship could carry. To avoid the tax, thousands of Chinese immigrants were dropped off in South Australia and forced to walk over 400 kilometers across the harsh outback to reach the Victorian goldfields. This anti-Chinese sentiment laid the dark, racist foundations for the 'White Australia Policy' that would be enacted when Australia officially became a federated nation in 1901.

Active Tasks

Q1.